

and comments. Respond as honestly and openly as you can, for your sake as well as theirs.'

Most of our friends reacted to our retirement idea with knee-jerk enthusiasm. "You lucky SOB. I envy you. I'd give anything to do what you're doing—just chuck it all out and sit on my butt for a while." But when they realized we were serious, they concluded that I needed very early retirement like I needed a solid dose of jungle fever.

Americans come down hard on nonconformists. We condemn those who challenge life's normal sequence of events. We are suspicious of people who dress, act, or talk funny. But to this day I'm surprised by the strong negative reactions of those closest to us.

One woman really ripped into me. She's a brilliant, high-energy executive. She laughs easily, and she's a good friend. I told her I planned to retire, and we discussed it for half an hour. I could see her heating up, but when she finally let me have it I was bowled over. "You're a gutless weasel," she sneered. "You reach a career plateau and fall apart. You want to quit. That's the reaction of a weak-kneed, yellow-bellied, chicken-livered coward."

Hey, give me a break!

She denies she ever said those things, but that's the way I heard her in my overly sensitive state. Others were more delicate. But almost all our American friends and family advised against very early retirement. The rule is:

Don't expect a little help from your friends

Why did friends react so vehemently? Some, like my friend, seem to view winning the career game as life itself. To them, retirement isn't an exciting chance to grow but a shameful rejection of life's most sacred contest. Others think being rich matters most. They refuse to make the sacrifices involved in living with less. Others have ethical or moral objections: one works; retiring is wrong. Still others feel threatened: the idea of retiring at age 35 challenges their